

plementation at the local level has left a lot to be desired. For instance, while the state Government allocated funds for rebuilding of hutments in many flood-affected districts, the authorities wasted more than three months in reaching out to the victims. Even those who have fortunately received government assistance for rebuilding their homes are equally crestfallen because of the inadequate relief.

Although Supaul District Magistrate N. Sarvan Kumar insists that the flood victims have been taken care of, thanks to the additional compensation from the Chief Minister's Relief Fund, the basic question of providing a reasonable roof over a Kosi-scarred family remains unanswered. Saharsa Divisional Commissioner Hemchandra Sirohi claims that the relief process is in full swing. Beyond the claims, however, the Rs 2,000 assistance to each family from the Calamity Relief Fund (CRF) for rebuilding houses appears nothing but a cruel joke for those who still await government assistance.

The chief minister has also sought additional financial assistance from the Centre for massive reconstruction and rehabilitation efforts. To begin with, Nitish wants Rs 1 lakh for every house destroyed in floodwater. The Centre, however, has remained silent after initially granting Rs 1,010 crore for relief efforts. Meanwhile, the survivors are fighting misery on several fronts. For one, there have been a series of boat mishaps in almost all flood-affected districts because the locals are now forced to board rickety, makeshift boats to reach destinations, as the Kosi floods have washed away dozens of bridges, culverts and link roads.



ALTHOUGH THE BIHAR GOVERNMENT HAS PROVIDED RELIEF, MANY VICTIMS ARE YET TO RECEIVE AID.



WHILE HIS FAMILY MOVED TO GUJARAT, JAYNARAYAN CHOUDHARY OF MADHEPURA HAS STAYED BACK TO GUARD HIS BROKEN HOUSE AND WAITS FOR COMPENSATION

Meanwhile, even months after the breach in the Kusaha embankment in Nepal that caused the flood disaster, the state Water Resources Department (WRD), which is responsible for maintaining and repairing the embankment, is yet to plug it. The writing is already on the wall with the WRD imposing a penalty of Rs 10 lakh on Vashishtha Construction Company last week, for failing to complete the pilot channel and cofferdams at Kusaha by December 15 last year. The delay, however, has cast a shadow on the repairing of the Kusaha embankment before the March 31 deadline.

Clearly, the WRD does not seem to have learnt its lessons despite appar-

ently being guilty of the callousness and neglect that made the Kusaha breach and the subsequent flood possible in the first place.

Beyond the immediate reasons, it is becoming increasingly clear that the Kosi embankment was poorly kept, security parameters were not adhered to, and warnings were overlooked both by the state Government as well as the Centre. Sample this. In October 2007, as part of the routine repair exercise, Bihar engineers had sought construction of a 80 m-long apron of boulders across a critically positioned spur.

The Kosi High Level Committee which determines the nature of repair work and gets it executed through the state Government, allowed only one-fourth of the original proposal. As it turned out, this could not sufficiently strengthen the vulnerable spurs where the actual breach finally occurred. Even now, with the repair exercise at Kusaha running way behind schedule, the Bihar authorities need some real sock-pulling to prevent an encore. Or pray for the monsoon to fail. ■